

The Itch

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Steven Lovan Cord, after greeting the last invited guests to his retirement party and refusing to accept a continuing role as an adviser to the Company, fell into a heap before Mrs. Donalsed on the floor. Boagaphish, Cord's grey and black tabby, whose attention had been on a balloon string wafting up and down, watched with awe and curiosity at Cord's convulsions. Near the scene, Mrs. Donalsed's looks of trepidation shot through the gathering crowd. Never had she felt more a mix of fear, loathing, and horror than when she heard the details of the news when her husband, who had been director at a University laboratory, died in a mysterious accident there. Boagaphish, cutting a swath between many sets of towering thin and thick legs covered in pressed black and blue cloths, stood over Mr. Cord's face.

Gazing intently at his wincing expressions, she sniffed his cheek angularly. Such a curiosity it was seeing him like this lying on the floor. Most of the time she found him engrossed in reading a newspaper or reports for the Company while sitting by the fire in the den. Other times she would find him in bed reading a book. She would hop on the bed and lie next to him, snuggling just at his side, purring intently. Between turning the pages in his book, he would lay his hand just next to her and stroke her.

Jacobs, the servant, pushed his way through the crowd and knelt down beside him.

"Mr. Cord, can you hear me?" Cord had stopped convulsing, and Boagaphish could hear his breathing becoming more rhythmic. She mewed softly.

Jacobs, who had arrived five years ago, was the head servant of a staff of six. He was entrusted by Cord to his personal effects and had the most Herculean task of watching over the CEO of the most valuable technological company in the world. He delivered reports, answered the telephone, and showed in streams of people in suits and briefcases and organized Cord's strewn documents while he was away. Soon, however, he would be taking

his new role as caretaker of the man who ran the company that built the true A.I.

“Go on, cat, go away!” Jacobs swatted at Boagaphish. She meowed accusingly and sauntered to the door to the hallway stairs, pausing to look back at Jacobs talking into a mobile phone. Others in the group pulled out their phones, and the scene became a wailing chant. Boagaphish decided she was hungry. She made her way along the wall, down the stairs, and to the kitchen.

Jacobs used to be nice to Boagaphish, a day far in the past, it seemed to her. It was winter, and snow covered the grounds of the estate; a time when she did not go outside. She bored quickly of ducking into open cabinets, racing up stairs, or peering into holes. She liked to sit in the window and watch the few birds there were resting in the swaying barren trees. When Jacobs was in the room with her, he would talk to her, pick her up, and pet her. She once found his caresses meaningful. He would feed her, making sure her water was fresh and cold and dumping out her stale food. But since Cord had started to change, everything was different. When Cord was restless and intensely emotional, Jacobs was distressed. At times Cord would be calm and witty, but the next moment he would yell throughout the house in incomprehensible rants.

This had gone on only for the past several years, ever since Cord relented that he had become an old man. After his retirement and relinquishment of his power, his mood shifted into shades of darkness. Boagaphish seemed to understand, his mind was atrophying and he was drifting away from life. He was forgetting his theories, his equations, his adaptive programs, and his passion. His life’s work realized in himself, had given him long life far beyond what he had anticipated. He was aged and tired. The notion of Boagaphish, who used to be of great comfort, slowly became an irritation, a reminder of what he had done to himself. It didn’t matter, he was forgetting everything save her.

A few morsels lay in her dish and she quickly ate them. She licked her face, washing an eye with her paw, then paced down the hallway to Cord’s room. As she approached, she could hear the flurry of activity in the room. She peered around the door and slid into the room to a corner where she could watch. Cord was lying on the bed, his hands placed over his chest, his eyes were fixed to a point on the ceiling as if he were watching a dance of invisible black shadowed creatures. His eyes moved to and fro, his lips pursed in a muted smile. For now he seemed at peace and the conversation in the room dwindled. The guests had been escorted out, and the servants

sent to clean up. Jacobs set a blanket over Cord and left the room.

Boagaphish walked to the bed and jumped to it in a smooth, gliding motion. She tucked herself under Cord's arm where she could watch his expression. His face didn't flinch, and he didn't move. Only his eyes closed, as did hers. In her dream she saw Cord as a young man. In the beginning there were only the two of them. They were in the tiny flat in the old city. Cord's room was filled with equipment, computers, various sorts of hardware, and devices. In a closet hung wires, wires she loved to play with while lying on her back. If there was one striking detail about the past she knew much about, it was wires. She twisted herself up in them, chewed on them, and chased them around the flat. Sometimes she dreamed of wires.

Her dreams drifted to pleasant times and pleasant things, to long pastures with tall grasses adorned with yellow flowers and butterflies and insects which she could endlessly stalk, chase, and pounce upon. The butterflies would always get away. Then, after such an exertion, she could lie down in the grass with sweet smells in her nose. She would sleep peacefully and dream. Her dreams were like a series of photographs devoid of any emotion, as if she were at the window thinking of herself outside. Had she been in the pasture or the garden? She didn't know. But memories are an emotional volley never linear; she only knew what she knew, her feelings the substance of her life. She knew nothing else. In her dream a strange sensation came over her. It started as a tickle in her side, like a small jolt of electricity, and soon moved down her leg. It was as if an insect was crawling into her fur and biting the skin underneath.

Cord stirred, Boagaphish awoke. He moaned softly, and she purred trying to comfort him, snuggling in a little tighter. His arm moved from his chest to her back where he stroked her gingerly. She could feel his emotions, his shifting state from calm to fear. His caress became weak and distracted. The end was coming.

"Mr. Cord, can you hear me?"

Cord opened his eyes, they focused on Jacobs.

"Yes..."

"How are you feeling?"

Cord coughed and sighed. "As if the end is finally coming."

Cord hacked dryly. His side where Boagaphish lay was contracting violently.

"The itch...it's getting worse."

“Let me get your medication.”

“It’s too late for that.”

“It can at least make you feel better.”

Cord clawed at his side and his leg.

“It’s getting worse, sir. I’m getting the medication.”

Jacobs left the room and Cord turned his head to look at Boagaphish. The strange sensation from the dream came over her. It began in her hind side and moved down her leg. She gnashed at the spot. She frantically tried to quell it. Cord placed his hand on her head and stroked her fur. The itch slowly subsided.

“My lovely Boagaphish,” Cord croaked.

She sat up and peered into his eyes. His skin was deathly pale, his eyes the look of shattered crystal. Once his eyes gleamed brightly, now he was only a remnant of what he once was. She could hear his breathing, the heaving of his chest was slow and erratic. She could feel what was going to happen, her sense told her Cord was going to die. She hung her head and mewed softly. Cord managed his arm up and stroked her ears. She purred.

“I’m sorry to have done this to you.”

He slid his hand down her back to her side where his fingers probed the itch. She turned her head around and gnashed into the place. She gnashed again, but it wouldn’t stop. She raised her leg to scratch but the sensation wouldn’t go away. She was possessed trying to put a stop to it. She had to sooth herself, to stop the itch. Nothing she did, no matter how hard she tried, would put it to rest. She saw her leg as a blinding swipe, moving so quickly it appeared as a blur. She was pressing her claws deeper and deeper into herself to no avail. Soon, fur was coming off in large clumps, stripped away to the tender skin but the itch wouldn’t subside. She bit into her leg tearing into the flesh, pulling away layer after layer of skin until she discovered a curious sight within. Metal, she saw metal, like the shiny material she had remembered seeing in the old flat. It was now in her leg. Multi-colored pieces of string were wrapped around it, they were hard and when she bit into it, she got a shock. She did not understand but feared what she was seeing. Although the pain and shock gradually decreased, she continued to tear into herself.

He began slowly. “I should have let you die,” he said in a low tone. “I

have been at his game too long. And I see you have, too.” He stroked her as he had in the dark past, perhaps he could comfort her and express his love for her before it was too late.

“An unfortunate side effect to living past your time. I feel the itch too. It is a sign that death is coming. I am no longer afraid of death, I have used my feigned intelligence to extend my life by replacing my dying organs with artificial ones. Now no one can tell which part of me is human and which is machine. The real Boagaphish died half a century ago. I consumed myself in replicating her and a year later you were born. The necessary evils of such work, perhaps I should not have become a Cyberneticist. The programs, the devices, the wires that run through you run through me.”

She stopped scratching and suddenly looked at Cord.

“If only you could understand me. But you can’t, can you? I can’t stand it any longer, the itch has taken over my entire body. I am powerless to stop it. If I could...but Jacobs won’t let me. It’s not his fault, he’s just doing as he’s told by the Company. Don’t hate him for it.”

He continued to caress her. The itch that had risen to such intensity abruptly subsided. They lay together as the room became dark. His breathing became slow and less deliberate, his body twitched and his face winced. Her gaze never left Cord’s eyes and as the last glimmers of brightness left him, she closed her eyes and dreamt of wires.
